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In its quest to push the Indo-US nuclear deal, the Congress cut a deal with the Samajwadi Party triggering a pullout by the Left. It is now desperately negotiating new deals to cobble a majority and save the government.

DEALTIME

Folks

■ By Shankkar Aiyar

You could call it the perversion of the law of unintended consequences. In withdrawing support to the United Progressive Alliance (UPA) over the Indo-US nuclear deal, Prakash Karat has done to the current political landscape what Manmohan Singh once did to the economic landscape of the country. Indian politics, it would seem, has been delicensed and a free market to prop up UPA has been created. As with any fragmented market, the major players are hunting for alliances and acquisitions while smaller players are seeking consolidation.

Ideology is at a discount and support is at a premium. To be sure, Karat may argue that the animal spirits of political entrepreneurship were unleashed by the coming together of two visceral enemies, the Congress and Samajwadi Party, but the trigger was the vacuum created by the exit of

the 59-member Left Front. Even if one buys into Mulayam Singh's supposed backing of 39 MPs, the arithmetic of politics dictates that Congress will need another 20 to cross the halfway mark of 272.

National interest is the calling card whether it is the Left, the NDA or the UPA. Gambling for survival, the Congress is wooing everyone from large parties to single-digit-MP entities and Independents with a plea to back the nuclear deal and the Government. The undecided are willing to negotiate and the ubiquitous argument is: "We want to understand the implications of the nuclear deal." Never mind the fact that the deal has been debated intensely in Parliament. Some are blunt and others coy. If National Conference leader Omar Abdullah says, "We are not against the deal but we haven't taken a decision because we are not adequately briefed about the advantages or the disadvantages of the deal,"